

Gender, Power & Shakespeare: A Guide to Bhardwaj's *Omkara* and *Maqbool*

A study guide to the representation of women and sexuality in Vishal Bhardwaj's Shakespearean adaptations.



Essay Question

Consider the representation of women and sexuality in one or more films on the module. In what ways do the films adapt or contest the gender assumptions of Shakespeare's plots?

Omkara (2006)

Bhardwaj's adaptation of Shakespeare's *Othello*, set in the lawless badlands of Uttar Pradesh.

Maqbool (2003)

Bhardwaj's adaptation of Shakespeare's *Macbeth*, transplanted into Mumbai's criminal underworld.

Introduction: Women in Indian Cinema and Shakespeare

In Indian cinema, women are often found to be side products of the men around them, relegated to the domestic sphere. Sangeeta Dat argues that within Indian films, women are '**continually objectified and marginalised figures**'. Similarly, in Shakespeare's plays, women are largely powerless. Phyllis Rackin suggesting that Shakespeare's stories emphasise, '**patriarchal power, male misogyny, and women's oppression**'.

However, Vishal Bhardwaj subverts this assumption in *Omkara* (2006) and *Maqbool* (2003), breaking with the conventions of Indian cinema and creating female figures who encroach on the patriarchal structures they find themselves in. At the same time, women in these films still find themselves falling victim to the male dominated structures that surround them.



Emilia in *Othello*: A Pawn in Iago's Scheme



In *Othello* (1603), Emilia serves as a pawn for Iago's plans. She is loyal to him and does not question his motive for wanting her to steal the handkerchief in Act 3:

'What he will do with it, heaven knows, not I'

When Emilia does show signs of suspicion, Iago turns on her, snatching the handkerchief. Shakespeare, therefore, constructs Emilia to challenge her husband in displaying signs of suspicion but Iago re-asserts patriarchal dominance, using Emilia to fulfil his plan and then having little interest in her when she has served her purpose.

Indu in *Omkara*: A Reimagined Emilia

In Bhardwaj's *Omkara*, Iago and Emilia's relationship is constructed very differently, seemingly modernised with the two having a much closer relationship.

Centre of the Family

Indu is seen to be the centre of the family — not only the sister of Omkara but also the mother of a son with Langda.

Cinematic Intimacy

The cinematic use of a close two shot, showing the couple looking passionately at one another, gives viewers a sense of Langda and Indu's endearment for one another.

Fundamental, Not a Puppet

Through Bhardwaj presenting Langda and Indu's relationship as similar to that of Omkara and Dolly, Indu's character is reimagined as a fundamental part of the family unit, not just as a puppet in Iago's scheme.

The Cummerbund: Agency Over the Handkerchief

Bhardwaj also reanalyses the tragic significance of the handkerchief or cummerbund in *Omkara*. In Shakespeare's play, Iago makes Emilia take it in order for him to plant it on the unsuspecting Cassio. Whereas in Bhardwaj's film, Indu happens to find it on her own and wears it because she wants to, not at her husband's command. It is only on seeing it that Langda contemplates its usefulness, bringing further light to the idea that Indu is not controlled by Langda and plays little part in his tragic plot.

Heidenburg's Critique

Mike Heidenburg sees this as a less empowering characterisation, arguing Bhardwaj establishes Indu as '**another version of the common Indian cinematic trope of the self-sacrificing mother figure**'.

Counter-Reading

However, Bhardwaj's depiction of her is not self-sacrificing — she is an integral player in the film and is much more of an empowered female figure than the Emilia we are presented with in *Othello*.

Indu's Climax: Killing Langda

Catharsis Denied in Shakespeare

In the final scene of the film, Indu kills Langda. This is a moment of catharsis for viewers that was not granted to them in the original play.

Revenge for Family

Bhardwaj's inclusion of this climactic scene gives Emilia a more fitting ending — she has been betrayed by her husband and is therefore compelled to get some form of vengeance. Furthermore, her reimagined affiliations to Omkara and Desdemona, brother and sister-in-law, give her more of a compelling reason to kill Langda, not just revenge for herself but also for her family.



- ❑ In doing so, Indu takes herself out of the domestic, 'self-sacrificing, Indian cinematic trope', and becomes a far more empowered and integral player in the action of the film.

Nimmi in *Maqbool*: A Modern Lady Macbeth

In *Maqbool*, Bhardwaj constructs Nimmi as a character who holds many of the same traits as Lady Macbeth. She exists in a world dominated by men, possessing power over the men around her by displaying masculine traits.

Lady Macbeth's Masculinity

At the end of Act 1, Lady Macbeth masculinises herself by saying she would kill her own child.

Nimmi's Transgression

In a similar, more modern way, a woman being unfaithful in Indian, particularly Hindu culture, is seen as a moral sin. Bhardwaj creates Nimmi as a figure who immediately goes against this expectation.

Transgressive from the Start

Bhardwaj presents us with a transgressive female character from the very beginning of the film, challenging the norms of both Indian cinema and Shakespearean convention.

Nimmi's Control Over Maqbool

In the courtly world of *Macbeth*, Lady Macbeth consistently questions her husband's manhood, disrupting the patriarchy in challenging her husband's masculinity. Bhardwaj adapts this sense of control through Nimmi's doubtfulness in *Maqbool* ever being able to replace Jahangir Khan.

'Pandit is a rank liar, you'll never be able to replace Abbaji'

Bhardwaj's judicious choice to then quickly change the camera angle to a long shot shows Nimmi now leading Maqbool — a subtle indicator that in undervaluing Maqbool's power as a man, she has empowered herself.

Mondal's Analysis

Subarna Mondal draws on this idea, claiming that Lady Macbeth and Nimmi both **'create confusion in the realm of mental representation by exhibiting "masculine" traits'**, describing them as **'aberrant, uncontrolled, having a will of their own and imposing that will on their male counterparts'**.



Nimmi's Limits: Reduced to a Commodity



In Bhardwaj's film, it is not guilt alone that is responsible for the demise of Nimmi, so she cannot be wholly viewed as '**having a will of her own**'. After the tragic climax of the film and the death of Abbaji, inspector Pandit responds to whether Nimmi and Maqbool have been sleeping together:

'whatever was Abbaji's once, now belongs to Miyan'

This relegates Nimmi to nothing but a commodity and takes away any notion that she is '**uncontrolled**'. In this sense, the 'business' of Mumbai's underworld is set up in such a way that any man could have killed Abbaji and taken custody of Nimmi, rendering her powerless regardless of how outspoken she may be.

Dolly in *Omkara*: Echoing Desdemona's Passivity

In the final act of *Othello*, when Desdemona is murdered, she is passive and accepting of her unjust fate:

'kill me tomorrow, let me live tonight!'

She does not question Othello's motives. Similarities can be drawn in *Omkara*, where there is a lack of speech from Dolly in the murder scene. This voicelessness makes her seem weak and powerless — she exclaims that she does not want to live anymore and accepts her fate without defending herself.

Shared Passivity

Both Desdemona and Dolly accept their unjust fates without resistance, embodying the silenced, powerless woman within the patriarchal structures of both Shakespeare's text and Bhardwaj's adaptation.

Bhardwaj's Adaptation

However, Bhardwaj does adapt the tragic ending. The film closes with Dolly on a bed swinging in and out of shot, over Omkara's dead body. This overhead shot suggests a lack of bondage between the couple — a reference to Omkara's lack of loyalty to Dolly throughout.

Conclusion: Empowerment Within Patriarchal Limits

In both *Omkara* and *Maqbool*, Bhardwaj attempts to empower his female characters in rewriting elements of Shakespeare's original plots. Although he does adapt women in these films to try and be outspoken and challenge the men who dominate the world around them, they still find themselves as inferiors in the androcentric society they exist in.

Ultimately, in still setting his films firmly in regions of male privilege, be it Mumbai's underworld or the unchecked lawlessness of Uttar Pradesh, women in these films cannot escape the shackles of patriarchy, even if they are originally empowered.

Indu (*Omkara*)

Reimagined as a family figure with genuine agency — ultimately kills Langda, transcending the self-sacrificing trope.

Nimmi (*Maqbool*)

Transgressive and masculine in her power — yet reduced to a commodity after Abbaji's death.

Dolly (*Omkara*)

Echoes Desdemona's passivity — voiceless in her murder scene, though the closing shot hints at Bhardwaj's subtle critique.